

FIELD LIBRARY / ACTION CHECKLIST

Food safety after power loss

RECOVERY / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Keep refrigerator and freezer doors closed. Without power, a refrigerator keeps food safe for about 4 hours; a full freezer about 48 hours and a half-full freezer about 24 hours. Never taste food to test safety. Use official discard guidance and a thermometer.

Do now.

- ☐ **Note the time**
01 Record when power failed and avoid opening cold storage.
- ☐ **Use temperatures**
02 Check appliance and food temperatures when safe; appearance and smell do not prove safety.
- ☐ **Discard risky food**
03 After 4 hours without power or another cold source, discard refrigerated perishables such as meat, eggs and leftovers.
- ☐ **Check frozen food**
04 Food with ice crystals or at 40°F or below can generally be refrozen or cooked; use official food-specific charts.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Track the time power stopped and use a fridge thermometer if available. If time or temperature is unknown, discard suspect perishable food and use shelf-stable food. Spend scarce fuel on safe water and essential cooking rather than trying to rescue unsafe food.

Watch for.

Do not serve questionable food to people or pets.

People & practical needs.

Plan a safe meal for each person before using the most vulnerable refrigerated food. Include infant feeding and food allergies

Next decision.

Clean appliances and replace spoiled supplies. Keep thermometers available before the next outage.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

SOURCES / SCOPE / LIMITS

Source-linked civilian guidance, not independent clinical or specialist certification. U.S. references; emergency numbers and services differ. Training and product instructions remain essential.

Food safety after power loss · official guidance

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/food-safety-outage/>